



Nayanthara: One of the few names most likely to pop up when one says female superstar of the south. Known for shouldering many female-fronted narratives in Tamil, her Hindi cinema debut finally happens with another superstar—SRK in the Atlee-directed *Jawan*

Rashmika Mandanna: After making her debut in Kannada hit *Kirik Party,* she forayed into Telugu films, featuring in hits like *Geetha Govindam* and *Pushpa: The Rise.* Bollywood's calling next with three films, including one with Big B (*Goodbye*) and another with Ranbir Kapoor (*Animal*)



Anushka Shetty: Heralded as the "Lady Superstar" of the South and one of its highest-paid actresses, Shetty is best known for *Rudhramadevi, Size Zero* and her warrior princess act in the blockbuster *Bahubali* franchise

tention to detail, while dubbing in other languages for instance, is key to the wider reach. "If you make a very good movie and keep it to yourself, nobody will know." The call to invest in marketing wasn't just a gut feeling but a move backed by field, telephonic and online surveys. "We wanted to know whether *KGF: Chapter 1* had reached the wider audience," he says. For Chapter 2, the budget increased tenfold and collections, too, increased in that order. Currently, Hombale Films has 14 movies in the pipeline across Telugu, Kannada, Tamil and Malayalam, including *Salaar* starring Prabhas of *Bahubali* fame and directed by Prashant Neel, who helmed *KGF*. "We are planning to have one pan-India movie every year," says Gowda. "The others will be a kind of a mix of two languages or something like that."

Not every South movie, though, is cut out to be pan-Indian. For every *Pushpa*, *KGF* and *RRR*, umpteen films leave no impression despite the presence of bankable stars like Prabhas in *Radhe Shyam* or do stellar business in their home state such as the recent Tamil film *Vikram,* which became Kamal Haasan's biggest hit. "In the last six-seven months, there have been a lot of South films released of which we don't even know the names," Telugu filmmaker Sailesh Kolanu told Crime Tak. "There are many films that won't work even if they're dubbed, but some do." The language barrier, though, is fading. Both Allu Arjun and Yash didn't dub the Hindi versions of *Pushpa* and *KGF*, but still struck a chord. It's noteworthy that the likes of Prabhas, Allu Arvind and Yash didn't need to do a Hindi film to attain nationwide popularity. For Thadani, it makes their achievement bigger than those of Rajinikanth, Chiranjeevi or Nagarjuna, who have done their share of Hindi films. Renowned Telugu film producer Allu Arvind says, "Indian cinema is going through a cataclysmic churn. The lines between Hindi and other regional language cinema are slowly being diffused. Indian cinema is going to the next level with those from the South contributing to the new genre of Indian cinema faster." As Allu Arjun gears himself up for *Pushpa: The Rule*, the most awaited release of 2023, he knows that the only way it can live up to the enormous expectations is by staying rooted and honest in its intent. "The making doesn't change," he says. "We keep in mind the nuances people like and recreate the highs." A month away from the shoot, the actor brushes up on those iconic poses which the nation came to love for an INDIA TODAY shoot. They flow with an effortless ease. As they say, '*Pushpa flower nahin, power hai*!' ■

–with Amarnath K. Menon